

The Little Cardinal's Promise

THE LITTLE CARDINAL'S PROMISE

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CARDINAL PRESS

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Cardinal Press

ISBN: [to be assigned]

First edition, 2026

For the ones watching the windows.

Mateo's grandpa was the kind of grandpa
who showed up.

[Illustration 1]

Boy and grandpa in a driveway. Ball gloves. An old red truck.

He came to the games Mateo He was always in the third
won, row.
and the games Mateo lost. Arms crossed. Watching.

[Illustration 2]

Bleachers. Grandpa in the third row. Boy waving from the field.

Saturdays were for fly
balls.

A hundred of them,
then a hundred more.

"One more,"
Grandpa always
said.

It was never
just one more.

[Illustration 3]

A park at golden hour. A ball high in the sky.

Grandpa made one promise,
and only one.

"No matter what," he
said,
"I will always show up
for you."

[Illustration 4]

A pinky promise, close up. Big hand and small hand.

One winter, Grandpa got
sick.

His naps got longer. His
voice got softer.

But when Mateo sat beside
him,

Grandpa still smiled the
smile that meant:
you're mine, and I'm glad.

[Illustration 5]

Quiet bedroom. The boy's drawings taped to the wall.

Mama said

Grandpa's

body was

tired,

and that

some tired

doesn't get

better.

"Then who will

show up for

me?" Mateo

asked.

Grandpa

heard him. He

held out his

hand.

"Watch for

me,"

Grandpa

whispered.

"I keep my

promises."

[Illustration 6]

The boy's hand in grandpa's. Faces close.

Grandpa died
on a snowy day.

The house got quiet.
The truck stayed
parked.

Mateo didn't
want breakfast.
He didn't want
fly balls.
He didn't want
anything at all.

[Illustration 7]

Snow falling on the red truck. One lit window.

The quiet stayed a long time.

[Illustration 8]

Wordless winter. The empty third row of the bleachers, dusted with snow.

One cold morning, Mateo heard a tap. Tap. Tap-tap.

[Illustration 9]

The boy looking up from his cereal.

On the window sat a bird. Not a brown bird. A red bird. Red right at
Mateo. It looked
as Grandpa's truck. And it
stayed.

[Illustration 10]

THE key image: brilliant cardinal on the snowy windowsill, the boy's wide eyes.

"Mama!" Mama knelt
Mateo beside him,
whispered. and her
"It's not eyes went
flying away!" shiny.

"You know what some people
say about red birds," she said.

"They say a cardinal is how
love shows up... after."

[Illustration 11]

Mother and son at the window. The bird holding their gaze.

Mateo put his hand
against the cold glass.

"You came,"
he said.
"You kept
your
promise."

The cardinal tipped
its head —
the way Grandpa
did
when he was proud
and didn't say so.

[Illustration 12]

*Small hand on the glass. The bird's tilted head. Mirrors the pinky-promise
pose.*

On the first day of
school.

The cardinal didn't	At the last game of the	tap.
come every day.	season.	Tap-
But it came.	On days when Mateo	tap.
	missed Grandpa	
	so much his chest hurt	

—

[Illustration 13]

Montage of seasons: backpack day, ballfield, rainy window.

And when it Because love
came, "I see you. I that shows It just
Mateo always love you up changes
said the same too." doesn't stop where it sits.
thing. showing up.

[Illustration 14]

*The boy in the yard, the cardinal on the branch above — the third row of
the tree.*

Now, when the
world feels too
quiet...
watch the
windows.

Watch the fences and the
branches and the snow.

Red keeps
its
promises.

[Illustration 15]

Final page: the cardinal in flight over the neighborhood at dawn.

A NOTE FOR GROWN-UPS

When you talk with a child about death, use the real words. Say died, not went to sleep. Let them see that you miss the person too; grief shared is grief halved, even for the smallest hearts.

And when a red bird lands, let it be a comfort without being a test. The point was never the bird. The point is that love that showed up keeps showing up. It just changes where it sits.

*The true story of the cardinal is told in the author's memoir, *The Cardinal's Promise*.*